

ALBERTA FIRST RESPONDERS ASSOCIATION CRISIS COMMUNICATIONS PLAYBOOK

For Internal Use — President & Leadership Team Only

Prepared by Vaishally Bhatti, Volunteer CMO | March 2026 | Review Annually

 **ONE RULE ABOVE ALL ELSE: People first. Facts before opinions. Silence is not safety.**

SECTION 1 | What This Is & How To Use It

A crisis will happen. It may be a member's death. A media story. A funding allegation. A mental health incident that becomes public. It may arrive with zero warning at 11 p.m. on a Sunday.

This playbook is your guide for those moments. It tells you what to do, in what order, and how to communicate — to your members, to the public, and to the media.

Read it now. Don't wait for a crisis to open it.

How to Use This Playbook

1. Identify the type of situation.
2. Go to the relevant section for instructions.
3. Fill in only the confirmed facts — names, dates, verified details.
4. Do not change the core messaging structure or tone.
5. Get approval from the Crisis Lead (Jerry) before anything goes public.
6. Deploy in order: Internal team → Families → Owned channels → Media.

The Three Things That Destroy Organizations in a Crisis

- 1** Saying nothing — silence looks like guilt. The story gets written without you.
- 2** Saying too much, too fast — guessing publicly is worse than waiting. Stick to confirmed facts.
- 3** Being inconsistent — one message from Jerry, a different one from a board member, a third from social. Trust is gone instantly.

SECTION 2 | Before a Crisis — The Preparation Steps

These steps are done now, while things are calm. They are what makes the difference when they're not.

The best time to prepare for a crisis is before it happens. The second best time is right now.

Step 1 — Know Your Risks

Before you can plan, you need to be honest about what could go wrong. For AFRA, real risks include:

- A member dies by suicide and their family blames AFRA
- A donation or funding allegation surfaces publicly
- A media story questions whether AFRA's peer support is qualified
- An internal member conflict becomes public
- A partner organization (EPS, EMS) is involved in a public incident and AFRA is mentioned
- A data breach involving member mental health information
- False information spreads on social media about the organization

Action Item: Once a year, Jerry and the Board sit down and ask — 'What could hurt us? What would we do if it happened?' Write it down. That list becomes your preparation.

Step 2 — Build Your Crisis Team

You cannot manage a crisis alone. Before one happens, decide who is on the team.

Role	Responsibility	Person
Crisis Lead	Final approval on all statements. Speaks first.	Jerry Galliford
Communications Lead	Drafts all messaging. Routes for approval.	CMO (Vaishally Bhatti)
Operations Contact	Gathers confirmed facts from inside AFRA.	TBD — assign before crisis
Legal / Advisor	Consulted before any statement involving legal risk.	TBD — identify in advance
Member Support Lead	Communicates directly with affected members or families.	TBD — assign before crisis

Rule: No one speaks publicly without the Crisis Lead's approval. Not board members. Not volunteers. Not well-meaning supporters.

Step 3 — Choose Your Spokesperson

One voice. In a crisis, AFRA speaks with one voice.

Most of the time, that is Jerry. He is the founder. His story is real and known. His credibility with first responders is earned.

Identify a backup now. If Jerry is unavailable, who speaks? That person should be decided — and trained — before they're ever needed.

What Makes a Good Spokesperson

- Calm under pressure
- Can stay on message even when questioned hard
- Leads with empathy, not defensiveness
- Knows when to say 'I don't know yet' without sounding evasive

Step 4 — Train Your Spokesperson

Knowing how to speak normally is not the same as knowing how to speak in a crisis. Media training teaches you how to stay on message, how to redirect a question, and how not to say something you'll regret.

Practice these three situations out loud — with someone else asking the questions:

7. A reporter calls and says a member has complained about AFRA's peer support program.
8. A journalist asks whether AFRA is responsible for a member's death.
9. Someone posts on Facebook that AFRA misused donation money.

Could you answer those calmly and on message? Could Jerry? Practicing before it happens is the only way to know.

Step 5 — Build Your Contact & Monitoring System

You need to know when your name is being mentioned online before a reporter calls you about it.

Contacts

Keep a group chat or phone tree ready for your crisis team. Don't assume email is fast enough.

Monitoring — Set Up Today

- Google Alerts for 'Alberta First Responders Association' and 'AFRA Alberta' — free email alerts whenever the terms appear online
- Check Facebook Groups for AFRA mentions weekly
- Ask your member support team to flag anything unusual they're hearing

The goal: no surprises. You should never find out about a crisis from a journalist.

Step 6 — Know Your Audiences

When a crisis happens, you don't send the same message to everyone at the same time. Here is AFRA's priority order:

#	Audience	Why They Come First
1	Members & their families	Closest to the situation. Most affected. Hear from you before they hear from anyone else.
2	Board & internal team	Must be aligned before anything is public. No surprises.
3	Partner organizations	EPS, EMS agencies, health providers — professional relationships to protect.
4	Donors & sponsors	Trust and accountability matter here. They need to hear from you directly.
5	General public & media	Last to receive the full statement — first to amplify it if you're slow.

The rule: Internal before external. Always.

SECTION 3 | The First 60 Minutes — Your Checklist

Post this somewhere accessible. When a crisis breaks, open this page first.

🕒 0–15 MIN	
☐	Notify Crisis Lead (Jerry) — phone call, not email
☐	Activate Crisis Team group chat — everyone notified
☐	Confirm basic facts only — who, what, when. No assumptions.
☐	Select a Holding Statement — see Section 4 of this playbook
🕒 15–30 MIN	
☐	Post Holding Statement on relevant channel(s)
☐	Brief internal team — no external comments without approval
☐	Notify legal advisor if liability is possible
☐	Activate social media monitoring — Google Alerts + Facebook
🕒 30–60 MIN	
☐	Assemble confirmed facts in writing — not from memory
☐	Draft 3 key messages — see Section 5 of this playbook
☐	Confirm spokesperson — one voice only
☐	Commit publicly to when the next update will be given

SECTION 4 | Holding Statements

A holding statement is what you say in the first 15–30 minutes — before you have all the facts. Its job: show you're aware, show you care, and buy time to confirm details.

Use these as written. Do not add opinions or details that haven't been confirmed. Swap in only the nature of the situation (e.g., 'an incident involving a member') — nothing more.

**STATEMENT
A
General
Incident**

We are aware of a situation involving AFRA and are actively working to understand the full details. Our focus right now is on those affected. We will share confirmed information as soon as it is available.

**STATEMENT
B
Member
Welfare**

The safety and wellbeing of our members is AFRA's highest priority. We are aware of this situation and are responding with urgency. We will communicate updates as we confirm the facts.

**STATEMENT
C
Public
Allegation or
Media Inquiry**

We take this seriously. We are reviewing the situation and gathering accurate information. We are committed to being transparent, and we will share what we know as soon as facts are confirmed.

**STATEMENT
D
Legal or
Investigation**

AFRA is cooperating fully with the appropriate authorities. Out of respect for the process and those involved, we are not able to share further details at this time. We will provide updates when appropriate.

SECTION 5 | During a Crisis — Building Your Key Messages

Once you have confirmed facts, every piece of communication — internal email, social post, media statement, verbal comment — should be built from three core messages.

No more than three messages. Everyone on the team says the same three things.

Message	Purpose	Example
Message 1: Acknowledge	Show you are aware and you care	<i>"AFRA is aware of what happened and deeply concerned for those affected."</i>
Message 2: Action	Tell people what you are doing right now	<i>"We are working with [authorities/families/our team] to respond appropriately."</i>
Message 3: Commitment	State what you stand for and will do next	<i>"We are committed to transparency, accountability, and the wellbeing of our members."</i>

Fill in the specifics for each situation. The structure stays the same every time.

Step 8 — Assess First. Respond Second.

When something breaks, the instinct is to respond immediately. Resist it. Take 15–30 minutes to confirm these things in writing before drafting any public statement:

- What actually happened? (Not what you heard — what is confirmed.)
- Who is affected?
- Is it still active or has it concluded?
- Who else knows? Media? Other organizations?
- What is the worst version of this story — and is it true?

Step 9 — Finalize and Adapt Key Messages

Have no more than three main messages that go to all stakeholders — and if necessary, some audience-specific additions for individual groups. Keep it simple. The team already knows what type of information stakeholders are looking for. Stick to it.

Step 10 — Post-Crisis Review

After the crisis ends, hold a debrief. Within two weeks. Don't skip this.

Questions to Answer

- What did we do well?
- What information did we need that we didn't have?
- Did our team communicate clearly with each other?
- Did our public messaging hold up?
- Did we respond fast enough?
- What would we do differently?

Update this playbook every year or after any significant incident.

SECTION 6 | The Do's and Don'ts

✓ DO THESE THINGS	✗ DO NOT DO THESE THINGS
Release a holding statement within 15–30 minutes of learning about a crisis	Do NOT wait for 'more information' before releasing a holding statement — silence reads as guilt
Brief your internal team before posting anything publicly	Do NOT speculate publicly about causes, blame, or what 'probably' happened
Speak with empathy first — acknowledge the human impact before the organizational response	Do NOT let multiple people speak for AFRA without coordination
Stick to confirmed facts only	Do NOT argue with media, members, or critics on social media
Assign one spokesperson. One voice only.	Do NOT delete posts or comments — it signals something to hide
Update your statement as new facts emerge	Do NOT say 'no comment' — use a holding statement instead
Use the same core message across all channels	Do NOT share information from active investigations or legal proceedings
Document everything — what was said, when, and by whom	Do NOT go off-record with a journalist assuming it won't be used
Monitor social media and news throughout the crisis	Do NOT let personal emotion drive the public response
Ask your legal advisor before any statement with potential liability	Do NOT promise outcomes you cannot guarantee
Thank those who supported AFRA once the situation resolves	Do NOT assume a situation has blown over without monitoring for follow-up coverage
Conduct a formal post-crisis debrief within two weeks	

SECTION 7 | Channel-by-Channel Messaging Guide

The same core message goes everywhere. The tone and format adjust per channel. Always post internal first.

Internal Team — Email or Group Chat (Send First)

Align your team before anything is public. No surprises.

SAMPLE:

Team — we are aware of [situation]. Please do not comment externally until we release an official statement. [Name] is managing communications. More information to follow within the hour. If you receive media inquiries, forward them directly to Jerry. Do not engage.

AFRA Members — Facebook Group

Acknowledge quickly. Reassure the community. Protect trust.

SAMPLE:

To our AFRA community — we are aware of a situation and want you to hear from us directly. We are working through it carefully and will share updates here as facts are confirmed. Thank you for your patience and your continued trust in this community.

Public & Media — Website / LinkedIn / Press Statement

Establish the official record. Professional and measured.

SAMPLE:

AFRA is aware of [situation] and is actively working to understand the full circumstances. We are cooperating with [relevant authorities/parties] and supporting those affected. Further information will be shared as it is confirmed.

Facebook Public Page

Reach a wide community audience. Tone slightly warmer than LinkedIn.

SAMPLE:

We want to be upfront with our community. We're aware of [situation] and are taking it seriously. We'll post updates here as we know more. Thank you for bearing with us.

SECTION 8 | Media Questions — How to Handle Them

The goal when speaking to the media is not to win the conversation. It's to stay on your three messages, show humanity, and not say anything you haven't confirmed.

The Bridge Technique: Answer briefly, then redirect back to your message. 'That's a fair question. What I can tell you right now is [your message]. We'll share more when we've confirmed the details.'

Q: What happened?



SAY

What we know at this point is [confirmed fact]. We are still gathering information and will update when we have a full picture.



DON'T

'We think what might have happened is...'



TIP

They want details and drama. Give only confirmed facts. Don't fill silence with guesses.

Q: Is AFRA responsible?



SAY

That's exactly the question we're working to answer through a proper review. We're not in a position to draw conclusions before that process is complete. What we are committed to is being accountable for our part in any outcome.



DON'T

'No, absolutely not.' or 'We had nothing to do with this.'



TIP

They want an admission or denial to quote. Acknowledge seriousness without accepting or deflecting blame prematurely.

Q: Were your protocols followed?



SAY

AFRA has established protocols for member support and safety. Whether those were followed in this situation is part of what we're actively reviewing.



DON'T

'Our protocols are always followed.'



TIP

You can't verify compliance in the moment. Affirm protocols exist and are being reviewed — don't confirm or deny a breach.

A Final Word

Jerry built AFRA because first responders were suffering in silence. A crisis — handled well — can actually reinforce that mission. It shows you lead with honesty. You don't hide. You stay accountable.

How you respond in the hardest moments is who you are.

This playbook is how AFRA shows up prepared.

"Seek support. Stay connected."

Prepared by Vaishally Bhatti, Volunteer CMO | Alberta First Responders Association | March 2026